efficient, but we are not that efficient or that good. The strain is telling on us.'[42]

The relatively smaller foreign service is the result of decisions made right after Independence. At that time, Indian leaders were more concerned about India's domestic problems than foreign policy and were reluctant to commit too many resources for the conduct of external relations. As early as the 1950s, a foreign secretary noted: 'No one in Delhi was prepared to accept that there had to be a reasonable increase particularly of senior posts in the Ministry for the maintenance of a balanced ratio between the posts abroad and the officer cadre at home.'[43] Nehru, while keen to expand the number of Indian missions abroad so that India's international presence grew, was not in favour of the Ministry of External Affairs 'bulging at the seams'.[44]

Starting off as a small elite service, the IFS only recruited 5–10 people each year for several years. The exclusivity and small number of Indian diplomats led to the view that they were better than others. Quality was believed to be a substitute for numbers. Over time, the foreign service has realized their personnel crunch. Had the Ministry of External Affairs been strategic consistently and added to their numbers on a regular basis, India could have doubled the number of its diplomats in fifty years, keeping pace with demand. Bad personnel management for decades has led to the difficulties Shivshankar Menon identified before the parliamentary committee sixty years after Independence. The Indian government has now decided to double the number of people working for the foreign ministry to 1,500 and recruitment rates have now gone up. Thirty-two 'officer trainee diplomats' were inducted in 2014, as against 8–15 some two decades ago.[45]

Increasing recruitment is only one way to boost the size of the service on a permanent basis; another could be lateral entry of candidates for specific positions. The Indian Foreign Service has generally opposed lateral entrants into diplomatic jobs from other services or from universities and think tanks. Critics of inducting non-foreign service officials argue that it does